

Incident Alert 0003. TLP CLEAR.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU - Pro-Russian Disinformation Campaign "Operation Overload" Targeting		05/04/2024 3
	Fact-Checkers and Media		

Summary

The campaign targets fact-checkers, newsrooms, and researchers worldwide, aiming to deplete their resources and encourage them to amplify false narratives.

- The operation encompasses both domestic and FIMI aspects. While our report primarily focuses on the latter, it is essential to note that the amplification of this content to Russian audiences for domestic propaganda is also part of the strategy.
- The actors operate through a coordinated email campaign, orchestrated networks of Telegram channels, a network of inauthentic accounts on X, and an ecosystem of popular Russia-aligned websites, including the newly discovered Pravda network.
- A prominent tactic involves flooding media organisations with emails containing links to fake content and anti-Ukraine narratives, particularly targeting France and Germany.
- The actors use a tactic we call content amalgamation, which involves merging multiple content types and audiovisual formats to create a multi-layered, coherent story. This story is then strategically amplified across different platforms, creating a false sense of urgency among journalists and fact-checkers while lending credibility to an entirely fabricated reality.
- Pro-Russian Telegram channels initially seed the content, which is then amplified on other Russian platforms (VKontakte, forums, websites) and further disseminated to broader audiences.

Incident - When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

Between August 2023 and May 2024, a coordinated disinformation campaign, dubbed "Operation Overload," targeted fact-checkers, newsrooms, and researchers globally. The actors behind this operation, aligned with Russian interests, used multiple platforms, including Telegram and X, to spread manipulated content. They sent over 250 fake videos, photos, and articles to more than 800 organisations, urging them to verify and potentially amplify false narratives. The campaign's primary objective is to overwhelm these organisations, deplete their resources, and propagate pro-Kremlin propaganda.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Anti-Ukraine, anti-macron

Impact

Reach: Over 800 targeted organisations. Content Dissemination: More than 250 pieces of manipulated content. Geographical Focus: Primarily France and Germany, with spillover effects in other Western nations. Psychological Impact: Heightened anxiety and distrust among the public, polarisation of opinion.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: Degrade adversary, Discredit credible sources, Distort reality, Distract from true events, Dismay public sentiment, Divide public opinion.

Behaviour: Content Amalgamation: Combining different types of manipulated content to create credible false narratives. Platform Manipulation: Use of AI-generated profiles and automated account creation to evade detection and amplify content. Fear-Mongering: Strategic timing of disinformation to coincide with significant events, increasing public anxiety and distrust.

Recommendations

Action Taken: Suspicious emails and content reported to relevant platforms and organisations. Coordination: Increased collaboration among fact-checkers and journalists to share insights and strategies for recognizing and countering disinformation campaigns. Resources: Investment in advanced detection and analysis tools to identify and debunk manipulated content more efficiently. Public Awareness: Enhanced communication strategies to educate the public about the nature and tactics of disinformation campaigns.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link	Foreign security Ukraine	Analysis of over 350 pieces of manipulated content, coordination patterns on Telegram and and X, and documented policy, impact on targeted organisations.	Amaury Lesplingart CheckFirst Guillaume Kuster CheckFirst Aleksandra Atanasova Reset Tech	Incident report	Telegram, X, Kremlin-aligned websites